EnerSys (ENS): Buy

Analyst: Justin Wen

Mispriced on near-term industrial headwinds while A&D backlog surges 27% and AI data centers drive backup power demand.

BUY	$220	$168.72	+30.3%
RATING	BASE TARGET	SPOT (10/16)	UPSIDE TO BASE

$152 / $286	9.5%	1.185	$6.1B	11.7x	0.91x
BEAR / BULL	LIVE WACC	BETA	MARKET CAP	FORWARD P/E	PEG

Executive summary

We initiate coverage on EnerSys (NYSE: ENS) with a BUY rating and a $220 base-case target, implying 30% upside from the current $168.72. EnerSys is the global leader in stored energy solutions for industrial applications, operating through three segments: Energy Systems (telecom, broadband, data center backup power), Motive Power (forklift batteries and chargers), and Specialty (aerospace, defense, medical).

The market is pricing in an industrial recession, valuing ENS as if revenue will stagnate at a 2% CAGR with compressing margins. We see this as a mispricing. Management recently disclosed that the Aerospace & Defense backlog surged 27%, with the munitions backlog up 230% year-to-date. The Specialty segment is converting this backlog into revenue at an accelerating pace. Two company-specific catalysts sharpen the setup. EnerSys secured about $150M in DOE grant funding toward a $650M defense-focused lithium cell campus in Greenville, SC (construction H1 FY28), anchoring its missile-defense and munitions power backlog in domestic supply. On data centers, the DataSafe Noir lithium platform has 100 systems on order and 500+ units quoted to suppliers, with revenue inflection expected by fiscal 2028, while legacy lead-acid data center solutions still guide high-single to low-teens growth. Meanwhile, AI data centers with rising power density requirements are driving demand for advanced backup battery ecosystems, a market where ENS holds a narrow-to-wide moat through switching costs and its proprietary Thin Plate Pure Lead (TPPL) technology.

Q2 FY2027 results (September quarter) showed $935.6M in sales (+4.8% YoY), a 16.2% adjusted operating margin, and $217.8M in free cash flow. Net leverage sits at a comfortable 1.3x EBITDA. IRC Section 45X domestic manufacturing tax credits are structurally boosting gross margins and free cash flow, a benefit the market has not fully credited.

> **Our read:** The market sees a cyclical forklift battery company. We see a defense and data center power infrastructure play trading at an industrial multiple. The 2.1% revenue CAGR implied by the current price assumes the A&D backlog and AI power demand simply do not materialize. That is too pessimistic.

Base-case assumptions

INPUT	BEAR	BASE	BULL
Revenue CAGR (5-yr)	2.0%	**6.0%**	9.0%
EBIT margin	11-12%	**13-14.5%**	15-16.5%

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Cash tax rate	21%	**21%**	21%
D&A (% revenue)	3.5%	**3.5%**	3.5%
Capex (% revenue)	2.5%	**2.5%**	2.5%
Terminal growth	2.5%	**2.5%**	2.5%
Beta (decaying)	1.185 to 1.00	**1.185 to 1.00**	1.185 to 1.00
Implied target	$152	**$220**	$286

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Bull case: $286 A&D SUPERCYCLE

Greenville + DataSafe Noir hit stride: The $650M lithium campus breaks ground on schedule and DataSafe Noir converts its 500+ quoted units, pulling forward the fiscal 2028 revenue inflection and lifting the Specialty and Energy Systems growth rates above our bull-case path.

Bear case: $152 INDUSTRIAL SLOWDOWN

Verdict

What would change our mind

- Motive Power book-to-bill recovering above 1.0x for two consecutive quarters would signal the industrial trough has passed.
- Specialty segment revenue growth decelerating below 10% would undermine the A&D thesis.
- Loss of a major hyperscale data center contract to a competitor would signal moat erosion.
- Net leverage rising above 2.5x would constrain the buyback and dividend.

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Key themes

1. Defense lithium campus de-risks the A&D ramp ACCELERATING

EnerSys secured roughly $150M in Department of Energy grant funding for a $650M defense-focused lithium cell manufacturing campus in Greenville, South Carolina, with construction slated for the first half of fiscal 2028. The campus anchors the munitions and missile-defense backlog in domestic supply, EnerSys supplies power for missile defense, soldier power, and munitions (not the weapons systems themselves).

2. DataSafe Noir targets AI data center demand ACCELERATING

The DataSafe Noir lithium battery platform is purpose-built for AI data center power density. EnerSys has 100 systems on order and over 500 units actively quoted to data center suppliers, with meaningful revenue inflection expected by fiscal 2028. Legacy lead-acid data center solutions continue to project high-single to low-teens revenue growth, these systems retain strong staying power alongside the lithium ramp.

3. A&D Backlog Conversion ACCELERATING

Specialty backlog +27%, munitions +230% YTD. Revenue conversion is the key metric to watch over the next 4 quarters.

4. IRC 45X Tax Credits STABLE

Domestic manufacturing credits structurally boost FCF. Benefit is recurring as long as US production continues.

5. Motive Power Normalization STABLE

Book-to-bill at 0.9x as the segment returns to pre-COVID levels. Not growing, but stabilizing. The growth segments (defense lithium, data center) now carry the forward story while Motive Power acts as a cash-generative stabilizer rather than a growth driver.

6. Operational Optimization STABLE

Monterey plant closure ahead of schedule. Cost actions support margin expansion toward the 13-14% normalized range.

Other KPIs

METRIC	VALUE
Q2 FY2027 Sales	$935.6M (+4.8% YoY)
Adj. Operating Margin	16.2% (vs single digits a year ago)
Quarterly FCF	$217.8M (19% LTM margin)
Net Leverage	1.3x EBITDA (below target)
Quarterly Dividend	$0.2625/share
A&D Backlog	+27% (munitions +230% YTD)
DOE grant / Greenville Li campus	$150M / $650M (H1 FY28)
DataSafe Noir: ordered / quoted	100 systems / 500+ units

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Guidance

Management guides to sustained double-digit adjusted operating margins post-normalization of one-time tariff benefits. The company targets net leverage below 2.0x and continues returning capital through the $0.2625 quarterly dividend and active share repurchases funded by robust free cash flow.

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Reverse DCF: what the market is pricing in

At $168.72, the market is pricing in a 2.1% five-year revenue CAGR with base-case FCF margins held flat. This sits just above our Bear case (2%) and well below our Base case (6%). The implied verdict: between Bear and Base, cautious. To justify the current price with a 9.5% WACC and 2.5% terminal growth, one must assume the A&D backlog and AI data center demand contribute nothing incremental. We view this as overly pessimistic.

SCENARIO	2029 REVENUE	TARGET
Bear (2%)	$152	**-10%**
Market implied (2.1%)	$169	**current**
Base (6%)	$220	**+30%**
Bull (9%)	$286	**+70%**

Model

Full three-scenario DCF with live CAPM and implied-ERP tab:
https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1P7XCXbi9ycbOjm6FG7OF5TamNUi1Bocp54zpGv4oGLY/edit

Risks to our BUY

- Industrial cyclicality: Motive Power is exposed to warehouse and manufacturing capex cycles; a deep recession would pressure volumes.
- Customer concentration: Loss of a major telecom or hyperscale customer would impact Energy Systems.
- Lead price volatility: Lead is a key input; sharp price increases compress margins if not passed through.
- Defense budget shifts: Changes in US defense spending priorities could slow A&D backlog conversion.
- Competition: East Penn, Exide, and GS Yuasa compete on price in commoditized segments.

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